end of World War II … The technology they brought was efficient and sturdy, but also wasteful and unviable, heavy and ostentations; in other words, just too *Russian*."[21]

Institutionalization in the 1970s included the creation or strengthening of institutions for democratic participation, like labor unions and elected assemblies. The heady optimism and commitment that forged popular participation in the 1960s gave way to more everyday, systematic means of participation. The Cuban Revolution's vision of democracy was quite different from U.S.-style electoral democracy, but avenues for popular participation certainly existed in Cuba.

Democracy: U.S. and Cuban Style

"Before 1959 we had plenty of political parties, but no democracy," Cubans like to explain. For those raised in the United States, the type of democracy that has developed in this country sometimes seems to be the only, the inevitable, or the ideal form of democracy. But democracy has in fact taken many different forms over space and time. It's worth taking a moment to look a bit more deeply at what we mean by "democracy."

In essence, democracy has to do with systems or mechanisms for the people of a society to be involved in making decisions about how their society will function. Political scientists distinguish between *representative* and *direct* democracy. In a representative democracy, people participate in decision making by electing representatives to make the actual decisions; in a direct democracy, decisions are made by some sort of collective assembly in which all can participate. Most modern democracies also rely on some sort of constitution or founding document that sets the ground rules.

Democracy can be measured on several different axes. For example, who gets to participate? What kind of rights does the system guarantee? What kinds of decisions are subject to the democratic process?

Using the first axis as a measure, it is clear that U.S. democracy has become more democratic over time. In the early Republic, political rights were restricted to a small portion of the population; gradually,